International Teacher Education

Written Motivation

Student name	Dylan Schlepers
Student number	*5882966*
NHL- e-mail address	Dylan.schlepers@student.nhlstenden.com
Specialisation	History
Classcode	ITSB23V1MPES1-A
Supervisor(s)	La, Brian
Examiner(s)	La, Brian
Assessment date	4/11/2026

By handing in this product, I declare that the product is my own work and that it is free of plagiarism.

Part 1: Written Motivation of Pedagogical and Theoretical Choices

In designing this unit and accompanying lesson plan for the IB MYP *Individuals and Societies* framework (History specialisation), my pedagogical decisions are rooted in constructivist and social constructivist paradigms. Rather than relying on traditional, teacher-centered transmission of historical facts, the curriculum design emphasizes active inquiry, collaborative knowledge construction, and authentic assessment.

Theoretical Framework & Pedagogical Rationale

Central to this lesson design is **Constructivist Learning Theory** (Piaget, 1973), which asserts that learners construct knowledge actively by integrating new information into existing cognitive structures. In an international secondary classroom, students enter with diverse historical perspectives and cultural contexts. Therefore, the lesson incorporates student-facing inquiry questions framed to evoke critical thinking rather than simple recall.

Furthermore, **Social Constructivism** (Vygotsky, 1978) underpins the collaborative learning activities embedded within the lesson plan. Vygotsky's concept of the *Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD)* highlights the importance of peer interaction and teacher scaffolding. By engaging students in small-group source analysis and discussion, learners are encouraged to negotiate meaning, articulate historical interpretations, and benefit from peer perspectives in a culturally diverse environment.

To make the learning meaningful and contextualized, principles of **Situated Learning Theory** (Lave & Wenger, 1991) and the IB MYP **GRASPS framework** (Wiggins & McTighe, 2005) were integrated into the assessment design. Providing a real-world scenario (Goal, Role, Audience, Situation, Product, Standards) allows students to apply historical concepts authentically, bridging the gap between theoretical content and practical application.

Alignment with International Education Standards

Teaching History within the IB MYP framework requires transitioning from a narrow subject-isolated view to the broader *Individuals and Societies* approach. This necessitates designing inclusive instructional materials that cater to multilingual learners and varying background knowledge, aligning with the ITESS core competency of Intercultural Competence. Active learning strategies are prioritized to maintain high cognitive engagement, ensuring that students do not passively consume information from the board, but actively interrogate sources and formulate evidence-based arguments.

Part 2: Reflection upon E.S. 1.1

1. What I Learned During E.S. 1.1

Throughout Educational Studies (E.S.) 1.1, I gained foundational insights into both instructional design and the realities of classroom dynamics. Learning the practical mechanics of the IB MYP framework—specifically how to design units using GRASPS and construct student-facing inquiry questions—provided a structured approach to curriculum planning. I shifted my understanding of history education from merely teaching historical dates to delivering a broader, interdisciplinary *Individuals and Societies* curriculum that honors international perspectives.

On a practical level, stepping in front of peers to deliver micro-lessons brought the reality of teaching into focus. I experienced firsthand that teaching is both exciting and nerve-wracking. This experience highlighted the crucial need for thorough lesson preparation. I also discovered the value of active learning strategies, observing that student engagement and retention increase significantly when learners construct meaning themselves rather than listening to traditional lectures.

2. Development of Vision on Teaching and Learning

My vision of teaching has evolved from a traditional presentation-focused model to an interactive, student-centered approach. Initially, I viewed teaching primarily as the delivery of subject expertise. Through E.S. 1.1, I realized that effective teaching relies on key personal and professional teacher traits: adaptability, empathy, clear communication, and enthusiasm. Active learning is now central to my teaching philosophy; a successful lesson is defined by what the students are doing and processing, not just what the teacher is presenting at the front of the room.

3. Critical Engagement with Course Reading and Resources

My engagement with the course resources was practical and outcome-driven. While I did not consistently complete all pre-reading assignments prior to attending every session, I engaged actively with the digital modules, interactive quizzes, and core theoretical materials provided on the course site. This interactive format was quite different from what I was accustomed to in previous educational settings, but I found it significantly more engaging and practical.

At times, I strategically skimmed dense texts to extract core ideas, but I read foundational theoretical frameworks (such as Constructivism and Situated Learning) with critical focus. I recognized that these theories are not merely academic requirements for an assignment,

but essential tools that will shape my entire teaching career. Even when skimming, I retained key concepts because I actively looked for ways to translate theory into my own lesson planning and emerging teaching style.

4. Goals for First Teaching Practice (TP) in Quarter 3

As I prepare for my first Teaching Practice in Quarter 3, my primary objective is to explore whether teaching this specific secondary age group aligns with my long-term career aspirations. While I have observed educational settings through following my niece in elementary school, my nephew teach P.E. and Social Studies, and coaching gymnastics myself, leading a secondary school history class independently presents a distinct challenge. It requires deep subject-matter research beforehand combined with effective instructional delivery.

Specifically, I aim to develop my **pedagogical and classroom management skills**. I want to strike an effective balance between being a young, energetic educator and maintaining professional authority so that students respect boundaries without sacrificing a positive, supportive classroom environment. To support this growth, I am committed to improving my English language proficiency to ensure clear, confident, and professional instruction in an international setting.

5. Evaluation of Study Behaviour (ITESS Student Profile)

Reflecting on the **ITESS Student Profile**, my study behavior during E.S. 1.1 is best characterized as **Strategic**.

According to the ITESS profile, a strategic learner is *purposeful, resourceful, and focused on optimizing learning outcomes*. Throughout this module, I deliberately prioritized key assignments, foundational pedagogical theories, and high-impact curriculum tasks rather than spreading my energy evenly over every minor detail. While this approach allowed me to manage my workload efficiently and grasp the essential components of unit design, I acknowledge that becoming more *Eager* and *Balanced* will further enhance my professional growth as I head into my first teaching practice.

References

- Lave, J., & Wenger, E. (1991). *Situated learning: Legitimate peripheral participation*. Cambridge University Press.
- Piaget, J. (1973). *To understand is to invent: The future of education*. Grossman Publishers.
- Vygotsky, L. S. (1978). *Mind in society: The development of higher psychological processes*. Harvard University Press.
- Wiggins, G., & McTighe, J. (2005). *Understanding by design* (2nd ed.). Association for Supervision and Curriculum Development (ASCD).